Opportunity Space

Our project investigates team collaboration within technology-enabled UQ classrooms. Although students have access to a wide range of collaboration tools, their work is often divided between physical and digital environments.

Students might brainstorm together using butcher's paper or a whiteboard, then move to Google Docs, messaging applications or other platforms to continue working outside the classroom. This transition can create additional coordination work, make contributions harder to track and lead to duplicated or unclear tasks.

Physical collaboration also has limitations. A shared piece of paper allows students to gather around the same surface, but capturing it in a photograph does not preserve an editable digital workspace. Conversely, digital tools can allow simultaneous contributions but may direct attention towards individual screens rather than the group.

Our project therefore investigates how social and mobile computing can connect these experiences while preserving the benefits of face-to-face collaboration.

Improved Experience (Solution)

Zook is an interactive tabletop collaboration concept designed to bring multiple students together around a shared digital workspace. Physical figurines represent individual participants and introduce tangible, playful interactions into the collaborative experience.

The concept explores how a shared workspace and individually associated interactions can coexist. Rather than requiring students to work exclusively through separate personal devices, Zook aims to make collaborative work visible and accessible around a common surface.

The intended experience is not simply a digital whiteboard. It is a shared social activity in which students can discuss ideas, contribute to a common task and interact with physical representations of themselves and their teammates.

Our project also explores how collaborative work can continue beyond the classroom, including the ability to save and revisit a workspace.